DOCUMENTARY

Life At Sea

In a documentary that was lauded at Sundance, Sarvanik Kaur crafts a bleak portrait of a community whose traditional livlihood is in peril



Sarvnik Kaur first thought of making *Against the Tide*, her intimate documentary about the struggles of Ganesh and Rakesh, two fishermen with diverging paths and beliefs, while she was shooting her first documentary *A Ballad of Maladies* (2016) in Kashmir. The year was 2015 and she had just heard about the proposed coastal road that was going to displace Mumbai's Koli fishing community from their ancestral villages. Kaur remembered thinking about the overlaps in the story and her film, which tracked the anti-government resistance in the heavily-militarised region.

"The displacement in Kashmir is in the name of nationalism. And with the Kolis, the displacement was about to be forged in the name of development," Kaur tells me over a Zoom call. Her interest was piqued—more so because of her own family history of displacement. Like countless families during the Partition, Kaur's grandparents had to uproot their lives in Pakistan and flee to India. The filmmaker grew up seeing her grandfather ache for a home he could no longer go back to. In many ways, the question of who gets to lay claim to land became the natural starting point for Kaur.

Eight years later, Kaur premiered *Against the Tide* at the 2023 edition of the Sundance

OTT

THE LOVE FACTORY

In a four-part docuseries on Netflix, **Smriti Mundhra** looks at the different avatars of romance in movies by Yash Chopra and his legendary studio

Hindi films were an integral part of Smriti Mundhra's childhood growing up in Los Angeles. Her father, Jagmohan Mundhra, was a filmmaker; her parents briefly ran a single-screen cinema in LA, one of the few to screen Hindi films, and it's through these films she taught herself how to speak Hindi. But the "tipping point" was watching *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jaayenge* (1995). "I remember it felt different from other Hindi films I'd seen," says Mundhra. "It didn't feel like a separate part of my culture that I engaged with."

Mundhra, who is best known for introducing the world to the adventures of 'Sima aunty' in *Indian Matchmaking*, is back to directing another Netflix documentary series, *The Romantics*. The four-part series looks at the seminal influence that filmmaker Yash Chopra and his eponymous studio and movies have had on Indian cinema. Between them, Chopra and his son, YRF's head honcho Aditya, have directed over 15 films examining matters of the



MILIND SHELTE